

IN STEP WITH THE WORLD

For 50 years, Bharatanatyam exponent **Malavika Sarukkai** has been forging a relationship with the world through dance. Her new show, *Anubandh*, now responds to the pandemic

Q+A

Q. The pandemic hit the performing arts hard. How challenging was it for you?
For the first few weeks, I withdrew. After that, I felt I had to fill myself with positive energy. The only thing I have been able do in the past two years is dance. I have never taken a two-year gap in my life. Left to myself, I became a student of dance once more.

Q. Many took to doing online shows. Did you do any?
I didn't feel the need to. If I was on social media, I might have generated some work, but I am not on any platform. I liked being away—the most conversations I had in the past two years were with dance, and hopefully dance spoke back. Now I am very much looking forward to meeting my audience.

Q. Tell us more about your new performance?
This virus eliminated all geographic boundaries. We all felt the same emotions of despair and anxiety. After the isolation, I felt the need to connect to nature and people. *Anubandh* is a response to the pandemic and asks: Are we living in worlds that are isolating? Should we not be more inclusive?

Q. On March 6, it will be 50 years since your *arangetram* [stage debut]. As an artist, are you content with the journey?
There's a sense of fulfilment but also gratitude that I have been able to dance and create. I am grateful to my mother, Saroja Kamakshi, who provided me the environment and the stimulus, and my gurus—Kalyanasundaram Pillai, Kalanidhi Narayanan and Rajaratnam Pillai—who gave me a firm foundation.

—with Suhani Singh